

Jefferson Leal

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EDUCATION

University of Rochester

- Ph.D. Political Science (Expected 2026)
- Dissertation: Three Essays on Ideology, Populism, and Polarization
 - Fields: Comparative Politics, Political Methodology, Formal Theory (Minor)
 - Concentration: Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning
 - Committee: Anderson Frey (chair), Gretchen Helmke, Alexander Lee
- M.A. Political Science, STEM-certified (2024)

University of São Paulo

- M.A. Political Science (2019)
- Thesis: Partisan Ideology and Personal Income Tax Policymaking in Brazil (*in Portuguese*)
 - Advisor: Marta Arretche
- B.A. Economics (2018)
- B.A. International Relations (2012)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Substantive: Comparative Politics, Latin America, Populism, Polarization, Public Policy
- Methodological: Causal Inference, Text-as-Data, Machine Learning, Large Language Models

RESEARCH

Publications

Frey, A.; Leal, J. When Crisis Hits, Does Experience Matter? Evidence from COVID-19 Vaccination. Conditionally accepted at the *British Journal of Political Science*.

Book Chapters

- 2020 Lazzari, E.; Leal, J. Brazilian tax policy under the lens of inequality: Stable, persistent, and durable regressivity. In: Arretche, M.; Marques, E.; Faria, C. (eds.), *The Policies of Politics: Inequality and Inclusion in the Governments of the Workers' Party and the Social Democratic Party*. São Paulo: UNESP Publishing. (*in Portuguese*)
- Volume received Honorable Mention, 6th ABEU Awards (Brazilian Association of University Press Publishers)

Working Papers

- Leal, J. Which Issues Divide? Interpretable Ideal-Point Estimation from Political Text.
- Leal, J. Local Right-Wing Populism and Vaccination: Evidence from the COVID-19 Pandemic in Brazil.
- Leal, J. The Negative Ideological Reverse Coattail Effect: Reversing Democratic Backsliding in Brazil.
- Leal, J. Why Do Citizens Support Non-Democratic Ideas? Evidence from Latin America.

Work in Progress

- Frey, A.; Caetano, G.; Caetano, C.; Leal, J. Treatment Effects with a Bunching Design in Politics: Evidence from Targeted Transfers.
- Frey, A.; Leal, J. Ideological Alignment and Local Policy Provision: Public Security Spending in Brazil.

Policy Reports

- 2020 Prates, I.; Barbosa, R.; Leal, J. Black men and Black women are the most vulnerable in the crisis; however, a “new vulnerable” group emerges: White men and White women in non-essential services. Bulletin No. 3. Solidary Research Network.
- 2020 Prates, I.; Barbosa, R.; Leal, J. et al. Emergency benefit providing R\$600 needs to continue and could be funded by emergency contribution on high incomes. Bulletin No. 8. Solidary Research Network.

Research Assistantships

- 2026 Research Assistant to Gretchen Helmke, University of Rochester
Code review and methodological audit of conjoint experiment implementation.
- 2022–26 Research Assistant to Anderson Frey, University of Rochester
Web scraping, HPC-based data processing, and text-based measurement design.
- 2024–25 Research Assistant to Bonnie Meguid, University of Rochester
Human coding of femonationalism in European parliamentary speech corpora.

PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

- 07/2026 Blalock Lecture Series, ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan
- 04/2026 GIGA Institute for Latin American Studies, Hamburg, Germany
- 08/2017 Book conference for *The Policies of Politics*, Center for Metropolitan Studies (CEM), University of São Paulo

Conference Presentations

- 2026 PolMeth
APSA Annual Meeting (upcoming)
APSA Preconference in Political Communication & Politics and Computational Social Science (upcoming)
- 2025 PolMeth
- 2024 PolMeth
Latin American PolMeth
MPSA Annual Conference
Summer Institute in Computational Social Science (SICSS), University of Rochester
- 2023 PolMeth
APSA Annual Meeting
- 2021 MPSA Annual Conference

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Scholarships

- 2026–27 Democracy Center Graduate Fellowship, University of Rochester
- 2025 NSF Conference Travel Grant, Society for Political Methodology
- 2023–24 W. Allen Wallis Institute of Political Economy Fellowship, University of Rochester
- 2023 NSF Conference Travel Grant, Society for Political Methodology
- 2022–26 Lanni Summer Research Grant, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester
- 2022 Program in Empirical Policy Research (PEPR) Grant, W. Allen Wallis Institute of Political Economy, University of Rochester

- 2016–18 Master's Fellowship (CAPES), Brazilian Ministry of Education
- 2015 Undergraduate Research Assistantship, Department of Economics, University of São Paulo

Awards

- 2024 Graduate Student Teaching Assistant Award, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester
- 2024 Beck Third-Year Paper Award, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester
- 2024 Best Paper, SICSS, University of Rochester
- 2017 3rd Best Poster, 7th IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods

PROFESSIONAL EMPLOYMENT

Academic Experience

- 2017–21 Lecturer, Universidade Paulista, Brazil

Non-Academic Experience

- 2011–13 Planning and Logistics Analyst, Rockwell Automation Brazil
Inventory and distribution planning and statistical forecasting for Brazil, Chile, and Argentina.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- 2025–26 ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, Teaching Assistant
- Matrix Algebra, Calculus, and Probability (Grad.), Summer 2025; 2026, Prof. Tim McDaniel
 - Causal Inference II (Grad.), Summer 2025; 2026, Prof. Sebastian Calonico and Prof. Nicolás Idrobo
- 2023–25 University of Rochester, Teaching Assistant
- PSCI 389, Senior Honors Seminar (Undergrad.), Fall 2024; Spring 2025, Prof. Casey Petroff
 - PSCI 102, Intro. to International Political Economy (Undergrad.), Spring 2024, Prof. Randall Stone
 - PSCI 101, Intro. to Comparative Politics (Undergrad.), Fall 2023, Prof. Bonnie Meguid
- 2017–21 Universidade Paulista, Instructor of Record
- International Business (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019–2021
 - International Marketing (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2021
 - Geopolitics and Global Markets (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2021
 - Integrated Multidisciplinary Project (Undergrad.), 1st & 2nd sem. 2019–2021
 - Intro. to the Social Sciences (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019, 2020
 - International Politics and Economics (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
 - Economics & Markets (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
 - Contemporary Brazilian Culture (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2018, 2019; 1st sem. 2020
 - Intro. to Statistics (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019
 - Microeconomics I (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019
 - Microeconomics II (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
- 2020 IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods, Teaching Assistant
- Survey Design (Grad.), Jan–Feb 2020, Prof. Bruno Cautrès
 - Survey Analysis (Grad.), Jan–Feb 2020, Prof. Bruno Cautrès
- 2018 Department of Political Science, University of São Paulo, Teaching Assistant
- FLPo406, Research Methods and Techniques in Political Science (Grad./Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2018, Prof. Glauco Peres

AFFILIATIONS & SERVICE

- 2025 Co-organizer, SICSS, University of Rochester

- 2023–24 President, International Student and Scholar Advisory Board (ISSAB), University of Rochester
- 2022–23 Chair of Communication, ISSAB, University of Rochester
- 2020–21 Referee, *Leviathan: Cadernos de Pesquisa Política* (Political Research Papers)
- 2017–21 Referee for Instructional Materials, Office of Academic Quality, Universidade Paulista
- 2016–20 Junior Researcher, Center for Metropolitan Studies
- 2016–20 Member, Inequalities Studies Group, University of São Paulo

COMPUTATIONAL AND QUANTITATIVE SKILLS

- Programming and Software: R, Python, Stata, MATLAB, L^AT_EX, GeoDa
- Tools and Skills: SLURM, Claude Code, Codex, Web Scraping
- Quantitative Methods: Causal Inference, Survey Design and Analysis, Machine Learning, Deep Learning, Natural Language Processing, Spatial Analysis

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

- 2019 Graduate Certificate in Legislative Politics and Public Policy, School of Government Administration and Accounting of São Paulo
- 2019 Survey Analysis, Design, and Experiments, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods
- 2018 Teaching Improvement Program (120 hours), University of São Paulo
- 2018 Modeling Dynamics in Space and Time, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods
- 2017 Advanced Issues in Multi-Method Research: Integrating Case Studies and Contemporary Methods for Causal Inference, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods
- 2016 Summer Workshop on Public Policy, São Paulo City Hall

LANGUAGES

Portuguese (native); English (fluent); Spanish (fluent); French (intermediate)

REFERENCES

Anderson Frey

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Department of Political Science
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Alexander Lee

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Department of Political Science
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Gretchen Helmke

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